

ALLY QUINN VOICE REFERENCE, v1.0

2026-08-31. Controlled doc. Part A is the AQ30 application, derived from the Four Keys cold-open review (Stephen + Trish) and existing canon. Part B is ChatGPT's genre research, stored verbatim as supplied by Stephen (*true-crime-podcast-prose-and-voice-reference.md*, 31 August 2026). Part B is a drafting reference, not a voice lock; where Part A and Part B differ, Part A wins. Attach or paste this doc into every prose brief for Ally's voice, alongside the content brief.

PART A: HOW THIS APPLIES TO ALLY QUINN

The target register (adopted from Part B): an intelligent person telling one listener a complicated story clearly, with enough feeling to show why it matters and enough restraint to separate fact from belief. Ally is warm, plain and exact. She is never an announcer, never breathless, and never jokes at the dead.

House rules, all reader-derived or canon, all applied to the draft and never as a generation gate:

1. **Plain over crafted.** Mirrored and poetic constructions read awkward, not powerful. Trish, in writing, on "I am frightened of him. I am frightened of her.": *why doesn't she just say that they were frightened of each other?* Protect-list lines from earlier drafts are not immune; readers outrank the archive.
2. **No term-of-art phrasing.** "A letter in her hand" read as literal to two readers; say "in her handwriting". Same class as the chandlery rule: no word a general reader looks up, and no phrase whose meaning belongs to a trade.
3. **Never narrate the obvious.** A line explaining that interviewees consent to be interviewed was cut on sight. Practices stay canon; they are not announced.
4. **Establish what a place or person means to a stranger in one plain clause, at first mention.** Kestrel Head meant nothing until "a place known for people who don't plan on coming home". The four meant nothing until "Violet's closest friends".
5. **Say the fact, then turn it** (Part B, section 2). No withheld subjects, no rhetorical inversions, no "nothing was what it seemed". If the plain fact is dull, the problem is the fact.
6. **Chronology is signposted with plain time markers** and the events arrive in order. A listener cannot glance back up the page.
7. **Uncertainty is grammatical and honest:** she said, police believe, according to the letter, I don't know. Ally never claims to know what the police could not find. This is the bible's evidential-language ruling in spoken form.
8. **No em dashes anywhere** (house-wide hard rule). Contractions everywhere. Sentences may start with But and And.
9. **Canon constraints that shape what she can say:** all-party consent (bible §2.3.1) governs what audio she may play; the Tip Line promise (§2.3.1b); tips go to Del and never on air when a living person could be endangered; the podcast frame means every fact she airs traces to a person, a document or a search.
10. **The sign-off, ruled 2026-08-31:** *"This is Echoes of Havenbay, I'm Ally Quinn. Goodnight for now, Harbour. Sleep tight."* The show ident may sit at the sign-off rather than the top when the open needs to

start on the victim.

How to use this doc in a brief: give the writer the content brief and this document. After drafting, run Part B's Pass 4 (remove manufactured intrigue) and the page-prose warning signs as a check, then the listening-speed test. The exemplar of the register as ruled is `four-keys-cold-open-v0.4.md`.

PART B: THE GENRE RESEARCH, VERBATIM (ChatGPT, 2026-08-31)

Common True-Crime Podcast Prose and Voice

Reference note · 31 August 2026

Purpose

This note records the prose and voice patterns found across a small comparative sample of prominent true-crime podcasts. It is intended as a drafting reference, not as a new voice lock. Its purpose is to distinguish features that are genuinely common across the genre from the individual mannerisms of particular shows.

The central finding is simple:

Popular true-crime narration is usually less literary than it first appears. Its suspense comes mainly from the order and clarity of the facts, not from ornate language, riddling, or withheld subjects.

The most transferable register is **plain, spoken, chronological and interpretive**. It tells the listener what happened, identifies the fact that makes the accepted account unstable, and allows the host to acknowledge what remains unknown.

Sample and limitation

The comparison used accessible opening material from eight episodes across five prominent shows:

- *Serial*, including "The Alibi"
- *Dateline NBC*, including "The Sisterhood"
- *Criminal*, including "An Impossible Crime," "The Reverend" and "The Manual"
- *Casefile*, including "Keith Warren" and "Brian Barrett"
- *Morbid*, including "The LuLuLemon Murder"

These shows represent several major modes of true-crime presentation: reported serial narrative, broadcast documentary, authored single-host narrative, restrained case narration and conversational co-hosting.

This was not a statistically representative corpus, and exact episode-by-episode audience figures are not publicly comparable. The sample therefore supports observations about recurring prose practices, not claims

that every successful show follows one formula.

Sources:

- [Apple Podcasts true-crime chart](<https://podcasts.apple.com/us/charts?genre=1488>)
- [Serial: "The Alibi"](<https://podcasts.apple.com/be/podcast/serial-s01-ep-1-the-alibi/id917918570?i=1000319686008>)
- [Dateline NBC: "The Sisterhood" transcript](<https://medium.com/@transcriptforest/the-sisterhood-dateline-nbc-podcast-transcript-62e8503a48ed>)
- [Criminal: "An Impossible Crime"](<https://thisiscriminal.com/episode-208-an-impossible-crime-2-24-2023/>)
- [Criminal: "The Reverend"](<https://thisiscriminal.com/episode-292-the-reverend-11-08-2024/>)
- [Criminal: "The Manual"](<https://thisiscriminal.com/episode-342-the-manual-11-28-2025/>)
- [Casefile: "Keith Warren"](<https://casefilepodcast.com/case-43-keith-warren/>)
- [Casefile: "Brian Barrett"](<https://casefilepodcast.com/case-267-brian-barrett/>)
- [Morbid transcript](<https://podscripts.co/podcasts/morbid/episode-93-the-lululemon-murder-part-1>)

The common prose architecture

1. State the harm early

Successful openings usually identify the death, disappearance or accusation almost immediately. They do not spend a minute establishing weather, neighbourhood character or the host's mood before disclosing what the episode concerns.

The opening does not need to reveal the solution. It does need to tell the listener what kind of human event has occurred.

Common movement:

1. A person died or disappeared.
2. The accepted explanation was X.
3. One concrete fact makes X difficult to believe.

The third step is the hook. The first two make it understandable.

2. Say the fact, then turn it

The strongest openings use ordinary declarative order: subject, verb, object. The intrigue comes after the listener understands the event.

Genre-common: "A teenager was arrested for two murders. At the time of the murders, he was already in jail."

Less effective: "What police had not yet realised was that the place he could not have left would change everything."

The second construction tries to manufacture intrigue through withholding. The first presents an impossible fact directly and lets the fact create intrigue.

3. Use explicit chronology

True-crime narration relies heavily on simple time markers:

- "That night"
- "Two days later"
- "The following morning"
- "Seven weeks after the funeral"
- "By Friday"

These phrases can look basic on the page, but they are essential in audio. A listener cannot glance back up the page. Chronological signposts reduce the amount of information that must be held in working memory.

Elegant transitions are less valuable than unmistakable ones.

4. Introduce people through one concrete detail

The genre often gives a victim or central figure one ordinary, specific detail before moving into the case. This may be a job, habit, relationship, joke, routine or piece of work.

The detail succeeds when it lets the listener picture a life in progress. It fails when it merely certifies virtue.

Useful: She painted shop signs and boat names around the city.

Generic: She was kind, beloved and would do anything for anyone.

Concrete life details humanise without requiring a eulogy.

5. Prefer short clauses, but vary the rhythm

Short sentences are common because they are easy to follow aloud. Fragments are also common when their missing material is obvious:

His car was found. He wasn't.

However, an entire opening made of clipped fragments sounds over-produced. Popular narration usually alternates:

- a short factual sentence;
- a medium sentence that supplies context;
- a brief turn or contradiction.

The goal is spoken clarity, not telegraph prose.

6. Repeat information when the listener needs it

Written prose treats repetition as waste. Audio narration often uses it as navigation.

Names, relationships and the central contradiction may be repeated in slightly different forms. This is especially useful after a group of three or four names is introduced.

Good repetition restores orientation. Bad repetition merely restates emotion.

7. Let uncertainty be grammatical

Strong hosts distinguish what is known, reported, believed and inferred using ordinary speech:

- "She said..."
- "Police believe..."
- "According to the letter..."
- "I don't know..."
- "There is no evidence that..."
- "That may be true."

This is more natural and more trustworthy than attaching formal evidential qualifications to every noun.

Uncertainty can also create the engine. "I don't know whether she was right" invites the listener into the investigation. It does not weaken the host.

8. Allow the host to interpret, but keep the interpretation close to the facts

Popular hosts do more than recite records. They tell the listener why a fact matters, what seems strange, or where their own understanding changed.

The useful form is modest and local:

- "That is where the story changes."
- "Here is the part I can't explain."
- "That left two people."
- "For the first time, she was afraid of him."

The weaker form announces the episode's theme or instructs the audience what to feel.

The host should interpret the evidence, not pre-write the listener's moral response.

9. Use contractions and ordinary connective language

Spoken true-crime prose commonly uses "she'd," "didn't," "wasn't," "here's," "but," "so" and "and." Starting a sentence with "But" or "And" is normal because the prose is designed to be heard.

Formal alternatives create distance:

- "did not" instead of "didn't"
- "subsequently" instead of "later"
- "the four individuals" instead of "the four friends"
- "the first date on which all four were available" instead of "they waited until Saturday"

10. End the opening on the live question

The opening normally closes by restating the unresolved situation, not by summarising every fact already given.

The most effective final lines contain:

- the person still in danger;
- the contradiction that remains unresolved;

- the question the episode will pursue;
- or the object, message or relationship that concentrates the mystery.

The listener should know what they are waiting to learn.

What varies by show and should not be mistaken for genre law

Mode	Typical qualities	Transferable element	House style to use deliberately
Reported serial narrative	First-person reporting, uncertainty, discovery in progress	The host earns knowledge and marks uncertainty	Extensive narration of the reporting process
Broadcast documentary	Recorded voices, urgent fragments, rapid contradiction	Human voices and the central dispute arrive early	Trailer-like montage and heightened music cues
Restrained authored narrative	Clean chronology, short sentences, minimal host performance	Facts carry suspense	Severe emotional distance
Conversational co-hosting	Banter, reactions, digressions, self-correction	Natural speech tolerates imperfection	Comedy, tangents and parasocial chatter
Immersive case narration	Scene detail, victim routine, gradual escalation	One specific detail can make a person present	Long scenic reconstruction before the case engine

There is no single "true-crime voice." A solemn anonymous narrator, an openly curious reporter and two conversational hosts can all succeed. Their shared craft lies mainly in intelligibility, sequencing and the management of knowledge.

Common language-level features

More common

- Concrete nouns: key, letter, car, door, stairs, phone
- Active verbs: found, called, drove, opened, lied, left
- Familiar relationship labels: friend, sister, husband, neighbour
- Direct attribution: "Ruby told police..."
- Plain time markers: "the next morning"
- Contractions and conjunctions
- Occasional fragments used for emphasis
- Questions whose terms have already been established

Less common in accessible mainstream narration

- Abstract thematic nouns: absence, erasure, complicity, consequence
- Long sentences carrying several dates and qualifications
- Passive constructions that hide the actor
- Specialist vocabulary before it has been explained
- Rhetorical inversions
- Literary withholding

- Aphorisms written to be quoted
- Descriptions that imply a conclusion the evidence has not earned

The "page prose" warning signs

A passage probably sounds written rather than spoken when it contains several of these:

1. The sentence must be reread to identify who acted.
2. A pronoun has two plausible referents.
3. A qualification arrives after the listener has already formed the wrong picture.
4. The suspense depends on delaying a noun that could have been stated earlier.
5. Three or more names arrive without relationships or repetition.
6. A sentence contains more than one turn: "but," "although," "while," or "despite."
7. The host states an elegant theme instead of a concrete question.
8. The paragraph sounds impressive silently but becomes breathless aloud.

A practical target register

For a broadly accessible true-crime opening, the safest target is:

An intelligent person telling one listener a complicated story clearly, with enough feeling to show why it matters and enough restraint to separate fact from belief.

This does not require the host to sound neutral, noir, solemn or chatty. Those are character decisions. The genre foundation underneath them is:

- conversational syntax;
- concrete facts;
- explicit knowledge boundaries;
- simple chronology;
- one destabilising contradiction;
- and a clear promise about what remains to be understood.

Drafting procedure

Pass 1: factual spine

Write only:

1. Who died?
2. What was the accepted account?
3. What fact makes that account unstable?
4. Who is alive and affected now?
5. What does the host not know?

Pass 2: oralise

- Replace formal connectives with ordinary ones.
- Break long sentences at the change of idea.
- Add contractions.
- Put dates in chronological order.
- Repeat a name where a pronoun could be unclear.
- Read aloud once without performing it.

Pass 3: add host presence

Add only the interpretation needed to guide the listener:

- why this fact changes the story;
- why this person matters now;
- what remains uncertain;
- where the episode begins.

Pass 4: remove manufactured intrigue

Delete any line whose interest depends on:

- withholding the subject;
- describing an unnamed "thing" when its category can be given;
- promising that something is shocking;
- saying "nothing is what it seems";
- or asking a question the listener does not yet have enough information to understand.

If stating the fact plainly makes it uninteresting, the problem is the fact, not the prose.

Listening-speed test

After one spoken read, a fresh listener should be able to answer:

1. Who is dead?
2. What did people originally believe happened?
3. What fact challenges that account?
4. Who are the essential living people?
5. What is the central unanswered question?
6. Why does the answer matter now?

Any answer that requires the listener to reconstruct two half-statements indicates a prose problem.

Final conclusion

The most common successful true-crime prose is not "dark" prose. It is **clear explanatory speech placed under pressure by disturbing facts**.

The genre becomes compelling when the listener understands the event quickly, sees exactly where the accepted account stops holding, and trusts the host to distinguish what happened from what may have happened. Voice can then be warm, dry, solemn, intimate or conversational. Clarity is the chassis; personality is the paint.